Three Friends and a Promised Market

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MODULE 02 · FINDING IDEAS · CASE, READ BEFORE CLASS

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In the summer of 2011 three friends who had worked in Munich shared a wish. Jochen Engert and André Schwämmlein, two strategy consultants who had met at the Boston Consulting Group (BCG), had begun doctorates. Daniel Krauss had worked as a software developer at Microsoft.[1] Each of them had wanted a company of their own.[2]

Since 2009 a sentence in the coalition agreement of the governing parties CDU, CSU and FDP had promised to allow scheduled long-distance buses in Germany, which a law of 1934 had restricted.[3] By March 2011 the promise had become a draft law.[4] In June 2011 Deutsche Bahn, the railway, decided to hold back in long-distance buses for now.[5]

Engert later described a point at which the three had to decide whether to finish their doctorates and go back into consulting, to stay with their secure jobs, or to make the jump.[6] No source says when they reached that point. This case describes what they could have known at the end of June 2011.

Three friends and a wish

Engert and Schwämmlein had started as strategy consultants at BCG in Munich. Krauss recalled in 2017 that the two met there while playing football, and Schwämmlein recalled in 2018 that he had worked with Engert from his first job.[7] Schwämmlein also recalled that he and Krauss had gone to the same school and played volleyball together.[8] Krauss worked at Microsoft in Munich after working in automotive development.[9]

Engert worked on a doctoral thesis on pricing at the WHU Otto Beisheim School of Management in Vallendar, a university magazine reported in 2016. Engert recalled in 2025 that Schwämmlein's thesis was on innovative transport systems.[10] The sources differ on how the doctorates and the jobs fitted together. The magazine said Engert took a sabbatical in 2010 to write his thesis. Engert told a newspaper in 2017 that the two began their doctorates alongside their consulting jobs. An interviewer wrote in 2019 that all three were employed when the idea arose.[11] No source says who worked where on 30 June 2011.

Schwämmlein and Krauss had founded a company together before. The regional startup portal Munich Startup reported in 2017 that they founded it in 2005 and sold it after two years.[12] Schwämmlein recalled that it was an IT consultancy for mid-sized companies, that it did not scale, because growth would have meant more work for Krauss, and that building something themselves and carrying the responsibility had been great fun.[13] Engert recalled in 2025 that as a student he had organised ski trips with a friend, which often filled a bus, and that this was all his experience with buses.[14]

Each of the three said later that he wanted to found something. Engert recalled in 2025 that the three sat together from time to time and agreed that they would not stay in consulting forever and wanted to do something entrepreneurial, and that he and Schwämmlein first started doctorates.[15] Schwämmlein recalled in 2018 that all three wanted to found a company and were looking for the right idea, and that he did not want to be an employee or to draw slides in consulting for the rest of his life.[16] Krauss recalled in 2017 that he and Schwämmlein had been self-employed before and wanted to become so again.[17]

The rule and the promise

Under the Passenger Transport Act of 1934 an operator needed a permit for a long-distance bus line in Germany. The authority had to refuse it where existing transport already served the route satisfactorily, or where the line would take over tasks that existing operators or railways already performed without a significant improvement.[18] Green members of the federal parliament, the Bundestag, wrote in 2010 that, apart from exceptions such as traffic to and from Berlin and feeder services to airports, Germany had almost no scheduled long-distance bus service. In their view permit authorities usually followed Deutsche Bahn's argument that its own trains served a route and refused applications, and earlier attempts to ease the rules had failed.[19]

The coalition agreement of 2009 said, in the sentence the Green members quoted, that the coalition would allow scheduled long-distance bus services and amend section 13 of the Act.[20] On 6 July 2010 the federal government answered the Greens' questions. It said it expected the market for long-distance bus lines to develop and called coaches a sensible means of transport, economically and ecologically. It pointed to a ruling of the Federal Administrative Court of 24 June 2010, which in its words had already loosened the protection against competition considerably, because a permit authority could give decisive weight to much lower bus fares.[21] It said that, beyond a sensitivity analysis within the review of the federal rail needs plan, which was to estimate what allowing long-distance buses would mean for the plan's cost-benefit study, no further study of liberalisation scenarios had been carried out.[22] Asked what toll buses would pay, it gave the road-use costs that buses caused on federal motorways, taken from a study of 2007, as EUR 0.09 per kilometre in 2010 and EUR 0.10 in 2012, without separating long-distance buses from regional ones (Exhibit 2).[23]

By March 2011 a draft law to liberalise long-distance buses was in consultation. On 11 March the Verbraucherzentrale Bundesverband, the federation of consumer organisations, welcomed it.[24] The federation wrote that a coach was on average a third cheaper than the train and therefore attractive to travellers with little money, and that it let older travellers go from point to point without changing. It reported that Deutsche Bahn estimated that long-distance rail would lose about three percent of its passengers after liberalisation, and it concluded that train and coach served different groups. The train, it wrote, offered more comfort and good working conditions on board and was mostly faster, while the coach was limited in punctuality and speed by the risk of traffic jams but clearly cheaper.[25] The federation wanted the permit for a coach operator limited to the operator's safety and reliability. It criticised that the draft kept an operating obligation, the duty to keep running the line for the whole term of the permit, and the approval of timetables and fares. It wanted the ban on duplicating regional rail services limited to local transport, because the ban would otherwise force authorities to refuse a coach line if regional rail lost even a few passengers, though it called the ban of little practical importance for coaches, which hardly competed with regional rail. The federation wanted coaches to pay a toll for road use, like the charges trains paid for track and stations, and suggested examining an operator-neutral information platform and sales platform for all long-distance bus trips.[26]

Long-distance rail carried 126 million passengers in Germany in 2010, 2.4 percent more than in 2009, according to the Federal Statistical Office, and the average long-distance trip by bus or rail was 290 kilometres (Exhibit 2).[27] Engert recalled in 2025 that a Deutsche Bahn subsidiary had run buses between Hamburg and Berlin 14 or 15 times a day while long-distance lines were still restricted, and that this was widely taken for the size of the market.[28] He also recalled that the three had doubted for a long time whether the law would really come and whether the politicians would liberalise.[29]

Deutsche Bahn and DeinBus

Deutsche Bahn ran buses too. In August 2009 it started its first international long-distance coach line, between Nuremberg and Prague, on a link where it had stopped running trains about five years earlier.[30] A rail passengers' association reported that Deutsche Bahn had announced in August 2010 that the line had carried about 120,000 passengers in a year.[31] In June 2011 a news agency reported that a planned market offensive in long-distance buses had been called off because of the uncertainties of the coming liberalisation, and that Deutsche Bahn said it would for now make no multi-million investment in expanding its bus lines. According to the report, board member Ulrich Homburg said that Deutsche Bahn took no unnecessary risks and concentrated on its core business, and that for now it would not engage beyond its existing regional and long-distance bus activities. The agency wrote that Deutsche Bahn then ran more than 50 long-distance bus lines.[32]

DeinBus was a bus car-pooling service founded by three students. It organised long-distance coach trips and, according to a news agency, competed with Deutsche Bahn for long-distance passengers. Deutsche Bahn lost a case against it in April 2011. In May a Deutsche Bahn spokesman said that the railway would not appeal and added that the government planned a new law that would liberalise long-distance transport.[33]

The three described Deutsche Bahn's stance in different ways (Exhibit 3). Engert said in 2016 that they had taken it for granted that Deutsche Bahn would take the market itself, and that it did not find the market attractive. The magazine wrote that Deutsche Bahn turned up its nose at the idea.[34] Schwämmlein said in 2018 that a member of Deutsche Bahn's board had said that bus traffic did not interest him, after which the three took up the project again.[35] In another 2018 interview he recalled that Deutsche Bahn at some point said it did not find the business exciting and did not believe in buses.[36] He added that they had been unsure at first about entering, because the business lived on offering many routes and on being the largest provider, and a firm like Deutsche Bahn had every precondition for that.[37] Engert recalled in 2025 that the three had feared that Deutsche Bahn would put several hundred buses on the road and leave no room for others, that the board then said it did not find the market interesting, and that the three became attentive again.[38] The business weekly WirtschaftsWoche reported in 2016 that a Deutsche Bahn announcement of 2011 not to expand its own bus business was, in Schwämmlein's words, the spark they needed.[39] The three did not name the board member, and no source dates the remark they meant. Schwämmlein's magazine account of 2018 places it after a pause in 2009. Engert in 2025 and WirtschaftsWoche in 2016 place it in 2011, and the other accounts give no date.

Looking for an idea

Schwämmlein recalled in 2018 that the three searched for an idea together, ideally in a market in which digitalisation had so far played no big role, and that they came across the deregulation of the long-distance bus market. Two things appealed to him. The business was analogue, so digitalisation could enter, and deregulation changed the market structure and created new possibilities. He called it

a search for an idea for digitalisation.[40] Krauss said in 2017 that the team had collected thousands of ideas, from knitted socks to online portals, before the news of the planned law arrived.[41] WirtschaftsWoche wrote that Schwämmlein and Engert had kept a list that grew longer and had run business models for 50 products and services.[42] The sources name no idea on the list beyond those examples, and they contain no score, sheet or market analysis from the time.

Krauss recalled in 2017 that it had not mattered much what the business was, that the three knew little about buses, and that it was important for it to be not just another app or website but something tangible with an impact.[43] Engert recalled in 2025 that the old-fashioned market of mid-sized family firms, which had built good businesses over generations, appealed to him, that the three felt they could add value with a platform, a brand and technology, and that a liberalisation was a rare chance.[44]

How the three came across the plan was told in several ways (Exhibit 3). Engert recalled in 2025 a half-sentence in the coalition agreement of 2009 that they read and found interesting, and that they were then deep in consulting and had little time to look around.[45] Schwämmlein recalled in 2018 that the project rested for about nine months in 2009, because they feared that the liberalisation might not come.[46] Krauss was quoted in 2017 as saying that Schwämmlein came one day with the news that the law was to be loosened.[47] WirtschaftsWoche wrote that after a ski holiday in 2010 Schwämmlein and Engert remembered that the government had announced liberalisations in regulated industries, and added long-distance coaches to their list.[48]

Engert said in 2017 that a market analysis had shown 4,500 bus companies in Germany, mostly mid-sized, so that a business built on digitalisation, a strong brand and a central online sales platform could succeed.[49] Krauss recalled in 2021, hedging, that there had been almost 5,000 bus companies when they started (Exhibit 2).[50] The sources contain no other figure from the analysis. Engert recalled in 2025 that car-pooling offers were for the three at first a data source for which routes looked good and carried many offers, and a sign that demand existed. The sources do not say when they used them.[51] They also discussed how to organise the business, according to Engert, from buying buses and hiring drivers, to an online platform alone, to operators who ran the buses while the three supplied platform, technology, marketing and brand. The sources do not date the discussion.[52]

The sources differ on when preparation began. Munich Startup reported in 2017 that thoughts about the project began to take shape in 2010 and that the three founded a civil-law partnership in 2011, without a month.[55] Engert placed the first talks with bus operators in 2011, without a month.[53] Two other accounts of the length of the preparation imply starts around mid-2010 and in the second half of 2011.[54] The sources do not say whether any talk with an operator took place before 30 June 2011. Apart from the three themselves, they contain no statement by a traveller, and no paper that the three wrote at the time.

Finish, stay or jump

Engert recalled in 2016 that the three reached a point at which they had to decide whether to finish their doctorates and then go back into consulting, to stay with their secure jobs, or to make the jump and start a company.[56] In 2025 he described it as the point at which one jumps or does not.[57] No source says which path applied to whom. Only Engert and Schwämmlein are reported to have had doctorates under way and consulting careers, and Krauss had worked at Microsoft.

Family, friends and partners, Engert recalled in 2025, called the idea crazy, because the two had good consulting jobs and could finish their doctorates and go back.[58] He gave his own reason for the jump. If the three did not do it and someone else did and it worked, they would regret it for the rest of their

lives, and he had said, come on, let’s jump.[59]

Summer 2011

At the end of June 2011 the promise of the coalition agreement of 2009 stood, a draft law was in consultation, and Deutsche Bahn had decided to hold back in long-distance buses for now. Engert, Schwämmlein and Krauss each had a path in front of him, a wish for a company of their own and a market that the government had promised to open. Engert later described the question as the point at which one jumps or does not.

Exhibit 1: Rules and reform in long-distance bus travel, 1934 to June 2011

Date	Event	Stated by	Kind of source
1934	Passenger Transport Act. New domestic long-distance bus lines allowed only if existing transport did not suffice	Federal government	Government page
2009	Coalition agreement of CDU, CSU and FDP. Coalition will allow scheduled long-distance bus services and amend section 13	Green MPs quoting the agreement	Parliamentary paper
August 2009	Deutsche Bahn starts its first international long-distance coach line, Nuremberg to Prague, on a link where it had stopped running trains about five years earlier	Travel magazine	Press report
24 June 2010	Federal Administrative Court. A permit authority may give decisive weight to much lower bus fares	Federal government, citing the ruling	Parliamentary paper
6 July 2010	Government answer. It expects the market to develop. Beyond a sensitivity analysis, no further study of liberalisation scenarios has been carried out	Federal government	Parliamentary paper
August 2010	Deutsche Bahn announces about 120,000 passengers in a year on its Nuremberg to Prague coach	Rail passengers' association, reporting Deutsche Bahn	Interest group
11 March 2011	Consumer federation comments on the draft law that liberalises long-distance buses	Consumer federation	Association statement
April 2011	Deutsche Bahn loses a case against DeinBus	News agency	Press report
May 2011	Deutsche Bahn says it will not appeal and that the government plans a new law	News agency	Press report, date not settled
June 2011	Deutsche Bahn's board calls off a planned bus offensive. It runs more than 50 long-distance bus lines	News agency	Press report, date not settled

The two grounds on which permit authorities had to refuse a long-distance bus line, as quoted in 2010, follow.

Ground	Wording
1	The route can be served satisfactorily by existing means of transport
2	The line would take over tasks that existing operators or railways already perform, without a significant improvement of service

Source: compiled by the case writer from the Bundestag paper of 8 July 2010, the Federal Government's description of the Act, a travel magazine, the consumer federation's statement of 11 March 2011, a rail passengers' association magazine and two news-agency reports, see the notes to the text.[60]

Exhibit 2: The market in numbers, 2010 to June 2011

Item	Figure	Period	Stated by	Kind of source
Passengers in long-distance rail, Germany	126 million, 2.4 percent more than in 2009	2010	Federal Statistical Office, as reported by a trade magazine	Official statistic, second hand
Average long-distance trip by bus or rail	290 kilometres	2010	Federal Statistical Office, as reported by a trade magazine	Official statistic, second hand
Road-use costs caused by buses on federal motorways	EUR 0.09 per kilometre in 2010, EUR 0.10 in 2012, long-distance and regional buses not separated	Study of 2007	Federal government, in answer to a question on tolls	Parliamentary paper, a cost and not a toll
Passengers on Deutsche Bahn's Nuremberg to Prague coach	About 120,000 in one year	To August 2010	Rail passengers' association, reporting Deutsche Bahn	One side
Long-distance bus lines of Deutsche Bahn	More than 50	June 2011	News agency	Press report
Average coach fare compared with the train	About one third lower	2011	Consumer federation	Claim of an association
Expected fall of long-distance rail passengers after liberalisation	About 3 percent	2011	Deutsche Bahn's estimate, as the consumer federation reports it	One side
Bus companies in Germany	4,500, mostly mid-sized	Told in 2017	Engert	Recollection
Bus companies in Germany	Almost 5,000	Told in 2021	Krauss, hedged	Recollection
Trips of a Deutsche Bahn subsidiary between Hamburg and Berlin	14 or 15 a day	While long-distance lines were restricted, told in 2025	Engert	Recollection

Source: compiled by the case writer from the Bundestag paper of 8 July 2010, a trade magazine's report of Federal Statistical Office figures, a rail passengers' association magazine, a news-agency report, the consumer federation's statement of 11 March 2011 and interviews with Engert and Krauss, see notes in the text.[61]

Exhibit 3: How the three told the start

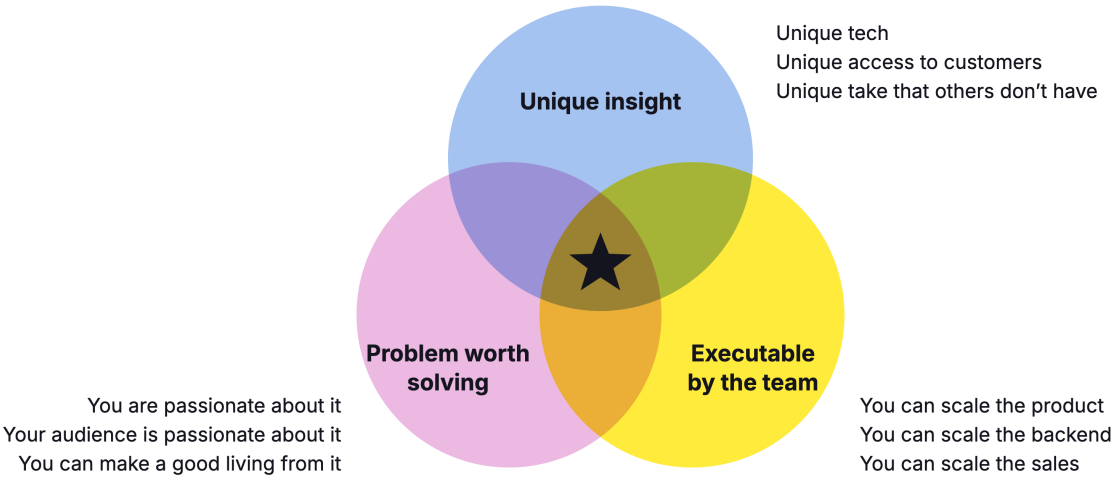
Teller, year and kind of source	How they came across the plan	Search for ideas and what mattered	What they said Deutsche Bahn said
Engert, 2016, university magazine	Heard of the coming opening while working on his doctorate	Worked on business ideas with his partners for years	Took it for granted that Deutsche Bahn would take the market. It did not find the market attractive
Engert, 2017, newspaper	The media reported that the market was to be liberalised	Wish for their own company had matured. Market analysis of 4,500 companies	Not mentioned
Engert, 2025, podcast	A half-sentence in the 2009 coalition agreement	Old-fashioned market of family firms where they could add a platform, a brand and technology	Board said it did not find the market interesting, in 2011
Schwämmlein, 2016, trade magazine	The passage on opening the market in the 2009 agreement	The magazine wrote that the three discussed what a liberalised market could offer	Not mentioned
Schwämmlein, 2018, newspaper	A bit of chance. The coalition agreement was the start	An internet platform for a real business that matters in people's lives	Not mentioned
Schwämmlein, 2018, podcast	Stumbled over the deregulation while searching for ideas	A sector where digitalisation had no big role, plus a change of market structure	At some point Deutsche Bahn said it did not find it exciting
Schwämmlein, 2018, magazine	A pause of about nine months in 2009, for fear the law might not come	Something that digitalisation changes fundamentally	A board member said buses did not interest him, after which they resumed
Krauss, 2017, regional portal	Schwämmlein brought the news that the law was to be loosened	Thousands of ideas, from knitted socks to online portals	Not mentioned
Krauss, 2017, podcast	Not mentioned	Knew little about buses. Not another app but something tangible	Not mentioned
Company-supplied text, 2018 and 2019, printed under both Krauss's and Schwämmlein's name	Read of the plans in the 2009 coalition agreement	Met regularly in the following years and played through business models	Not mentioned
WirtschaftsWoche, 2016, press account	After a ski holiday in 2010 the two remembered announced liberalisations	A list that grew, 50 products and services run through models	An announcement of 2011 not to expand was the spark

Source: compiled by the case writer from the interviews and articles named in each row, paraphrased, see notes in the text.[62]

Exhibit 4: The three by period, 2005 to 2011

	Schwämmlein	Engert	Krauss
School and studies	Same school as Krauss, recalled 2018. With Krauss, IT consultancy founded 2005 and sold after two years, reported 2017	Organised ski trips with a friend that often filled a bus, recalled 2025	Same school as Schwämmlein, recalled 2018. With him, IT consultancy founded 2005 and sold after two years, reported 2017
Job before 2011	Strategy consultant, BCG Munich	Consultant, BCG Munich	Microsoft, Munich, after automotive development
Doctorate	Innovative transport systems, recalled by Engert 2025	Pricing, WHU Otto Beisheim School of Management, reported 2016	None reported
Status in 2010 to 2011	Also working on his thesis, 2016 report. Employed when the idea arose, 2019 interviewer	Sabbatical in 2010 for the thesis, 2016 report. Doctorate begun alongside the job, 2017. In the doctorate in 2011, 2025	Employed at Microsoft, 2017
Wish for their own company	Recalled 2018	Recalled 2025	Recalled 2017

Source: compiled by the case writer from the interviews and articles named in the notes.[63]



The anchor graphic of Module 02. Unique insight, a problem worth solving, executable by the team

Endnotes

1. Engert and Schwämmlein at BCG in Munich. Thomas Wüpper, interview with Jochen Engert, Stuttgarter Zeitung, 2 July 2017, profile box, https://www.stuttgarter-zeitung.de/wirtschaft/interview-mit-flixbus-gruender-jochen-engert-fuer-uns-gab-es-schicht-keinen-plan-b-78939115.html, and Hans Luthardt, cover story on André Schwämmlein, StartingUp, issue 03/16, online excerpt, https://www.starting-up.de/geschaeftsideen/unternehmer-typen/andre-schwaemmlein-und-die-flixbus-story.html. Krauss at Microsoft in Munich. Florian Deglmann, article on the company with quotes from Daniel Krauss, Munich Startup, 13 February 2017, https://www.munich-startup.de/13105/flixbus/. Krauss as a software developer. Article on the company with a quote from André Schwämmlein, WirtschaftsWoche, 17 October 2016, https://www.wiwo.de/unternehmen/dienstleister/flixbus-der-unheimliche-siegeszug-des-start-ups/14680498.html. All accessed 2026-10-19. Translated from German by the case writer. The titles of these pieces are replaced by descriptions because they refer to later events.
2. Interview with Jochen Engert by Philipp Westermeyer, OMR Podcast #793, 16 April 2025, 03:26 to 03:46, audio https://audio.podigee-cdn.net/1876263-m-ebf7c71c8bb78221b9ccb7649deaa586.mp3, show notes https://omr.com/de/daily/flixbus-jochen-engert, accessed 2026-10-19. Interview with André Schwämmlein, LinkedIn Redaktion podcast, episode 12, recorded February 2018, 01:56 to 02:12, https://soundcloud.com/linkedinredaktion/12-andre-schwaemmlein-flixbus, accessed 2026-10-19. Interview with Daniel Krauss by Philipp Westermeyer, OMR Podcast #80, 31 May 2017, 03:37 to 03:44, audio https://audio.podigee-cdn.net/83591-m-620b4949529794dcf6edfb532399580b.mp3, accessed 2026-10-19. Statements from recordings are summarised from machine transcripts. They were not checked against the audio. Timestamps are those of the transcripts. Translated from German by the case writer.
3. Deutscher Bundestag, Drucksache 17/2535, 8 July 2010, preface of the inquirers, p. 1, https://dserver.bundestag.de/btd/17/025/1702535.pdf, accessed 2026-10-19, and Bundesregierung, “Mobiler mit Fernbussen”, archive page dated 2 November 2012, https://www.bundesregierung.de/breg-de/service/archiv-bundesregierung/alt-inhalte/mobiler-mit-fernbussen-420466, accessed 2026-10-19. The archive page states that under the Act of 1934 domestic long-distance bus lines were allowed only if existing transport did not suffice. Translated from German by the case writer.
4. Verbraucherzentrale Bundesverband, “Unternehmerische Initiative und politische Gestaltung”, statement on the Referentenentwurf for a law amending the passenger transport law, 11 March 2011, https://www.vzbv.de/sites/default/files/downloads/personenbefoerderung_kundenorientierung_pbefg_2011.pdf, accessed 2026-10-19. Translated from German by the case writer.
5. dapd, “Konzentration auf das Kerngeschäft”, Deutsche Handwerks Zeitung, https://www.deutsche-handwerks-zeitung.de/?p=114413, accessed 2026-10-19. The page metadata dates the report to 3 June 2011 and the page text shows 11 September 2011. A magazine of the rail passengers’ association (Signal 03/2011, August 2011) already speaks of a commitment of Deutsche Bahn to its core business, which supports June 2011, but no second report of the decision is opened. The report is in indirect speech. Translated from German by the case writer.
6. Linny Bieber, portrait of Jochen Engert, University of Stuttgart magazine forschung leben, issue 7-2016, section “Why leave a secure job?”, https://www.uni-stuttgart.de/en/research/forschung-leben/7-2016/daring_to_jump, accessed 2026-10-19. The English is the magazine’s translation of a German conversation.
7. Krauss, OMR Podcast #80, 03:29 to 03:48. Schwämmlein, LinkedIn Redaktion podcast, 01:32 to 01:47.
8. Interview with Schwämmlein, LinkedIn Redaktion podcast, 01:47 to 01:56.
9. Interview with Krauss, OMR Podcast #80, 03:29 to 03:37, and Deglmann, Munich Startup, 13 February 2017.
10. Linny Bieber, portrait of Jochen Engert, forschung leben, issue 7-2016, section “Smooth as silk”, gives the topic as industrial service pricing at the WHU Otto Beisheim School of Management in Vallendar. Engert, OMR Podcast #793, 03:49 to 04:02.
11. Bieber, forschung leben, 2016, sections “Smooth as silk” and “Why leave a secure job?”, on the sabbatical and on Schwämmlein working on his thesis. Wüpper, Stuttgarter Zeitung, 2 July 2017, on doctorates begun alongside the consulting jobs. Interview with Schwämmlein and Krauss, FAU alumni, July 2019, https://www.fau.de/2019/07/news/universitaet/alumni/interviews/andre-schwaemmlein-und-daniel-krauss/, accessed 2026-10-19, on all three being employed. Engert, OMR Podcast #793, 04:32, puts the two in their doctorates in 2011.
12. Deglmann, Munich Startup, 13 February 2017.
13. Schwämmlein, LinkedIn Redaktion podcast, 02:49 to 03:08.
14. Engert, OMR Podcast #793, 05:22 to 05:32.
15. Engert, OMR Podcast #793, 03:26 to 03:46 (see the note to the opening).

16. Schwämmlein, LinkedIn Redaktion podcast, 01:56 to 02:12 and 03:08 to 03:26.
17. Krauss, OMR Podcast #80, 03:37 to 03:44.
18. Bundestag, Drucksache 17/2535, preface of the inquirers, p. 1, quoting section 13 of the Passenger Transport Act. The paper is an official work. The year 1934 is from the Federal Government's archive page "Mobiler mit Fernbussen", dated 2 November 2012, https://www.bundesregierung.de/breg-de/service/archiv-bundesregierung/alt-inhalte/mobiler-mit-fernbussen-420466, accessed 2026-10-19.
19. Bundestag, Drucksache 17/2535, preface of the inquirers, p. 1. These are the Green inquirers' statements and not the government's.
20. Bundestag, Drucksache 17/2535, preface of the inquirers, p. 1. The original coalition agreement was not opened, and the sentence is known as the Green members quoted it.
21. Bundestag, Drucksache 17/2535, answer of the federal government dated 6 July 2010, p. 3.
22. Bundestag, Drucksache 17/2535, answer to questions 1 to 8, p. 2.
23. Bundestag, Drucksache 17/2535, answer to question 9, pp. 2 and 3. The figures are costs that buses cause, not a toll.
24. Verbraucherzentrale Bundesverband, statement of 11 March 2011, p. 2.
25. Verbraucherzentrale Bundesverband, statement of 11 March 2011, p. 5. The statements on price, travellers and Deutsche Bahn's estimate are the federation's.
26. Verbraucherzentrale Bundesverband, statement of 11 March 2011, pp. 2, 5 and 6.
27. Susanne Spotz, "Fahrzeuge: Fahrgäste nutzen seltener den Bus", Eurotransport, about 7 April 2011, reporting figures of the Federal Statistical Office, https://www.eurotransport.de/fahrzeuge/lkw/fahrzeuge-fahrgaeste-nutzen-seltener-den-bus/, accessed 2026-10-19. The original press release was not opened. Translated from German by the case writer.
28. Engert, OMR Podcast #793, 22:44 to 22:52.
29. Engert, OMR Podcast #793, 05:37 to 05:45.
30. Nicky Gardner, "Express bus to London?", hidden europe 44, 9 November 2014, https://hiddeneurope.eu/express-bus-to-london, accessed 2026-10-19. The magazine says that Deutsche Bahn had axed the last EuroCity train between the two cities ten years before the article, which the case dates to about five years before August 2009, and that the coach revived the link.
31. Deutscher Bahnkunden-Verband, "Gefahr für Bahn durch Fernbusse bleibt", Signal 03/2011, August 2011, printed pp. 24 and 25, https://signalarchiv.de/pdf/10000729, accessed 2026-10-19. A claim of an interest group, translated from German by the case writer.
32. dapd, "Konzentration auf das Kerngeschäft", see the note to the opening. The count of more than 50 long-distance bus lines is not broken down in any source. WirtschaftsWoche, 17 October 2016, reports that the few permitted routes, for example to Berlin, were mostly served by Deutsche Bahn's subsidiary Berlin Linien Bus. The rail passengers' association magazine of August 2011 names Deutsche Bahn bus companies that were also active in long-distance traffic. The investment sentence is the agency's report of what Deutsche Bahn said, and only the sentences on risk, core business and no engagement beyond existing activities are reported as Homburg's. The title of the WirtschaftsWoche article is replaced by a description in the first note because it refers to later events.
33. dapd, "Deutsche Bahn will Bus-Mitfahrzentrale nicht länger verklagen", Deutsche Handwerks Zeitung, https://www.deutsche-handwerks-zeitung.de/?p=107356, accessed 2026-10-19. One sentence of the report is garbled in the source and is read as saying that the company can go on organising long-distance coach trips. The page metadata dates the report to 6 May 2011 and the page text shows 9 September 2011. Sources differ on the service's start. A trade magazine says the idea began with a trip abroad in March 2009, when three students used coaches during a semester abroad. WirtschaftsWoche wrote in 2016 that it opened a first long-distance route as early as the end of 2011, which the agency report contradicts. Translated from German by the case writer.
34. Bieber, forschung leben, issue 7-2016, section "Why leave a secure job?".
35. "Grüne Welle", interview with André Schwämmlein, Forbes Austria, 10 December 2018, https://www.forbes.at/artikel/gruene-welle, accessed 2026-10-19. Translated from German by the case writer.
36. Schwämmlein, LinkedIn Redaktion podcast, 05:07 to 05:15.
37. Schwämmlein, LinkedIn Redaktion podcast, 04:55 to 05:07.
38. Engert, OMR Podcast #793, 04:37 to 04:55.
39. WirtschaftsWoche, 17 October 2016, second paragraph of the article, see the first note.

40. Schwämmlein, LinkedIn Redaktion podcast, 01:56 to 02:37.
41. Deglmann, Munich Startup, 13 February 2017, quote of Daniel Krauss.
42. WirtschaftsWoche, 17 October 2016, first paragraph of the article. The sentence is the journalist's.
43. Krauss, OMR Podcast #80, 03:48 to 04:01.
44. Engert, OMR Podcast #793, 04:55 to 05:19 and 05:22 to 05:32.
45. Engert, OMR Podcast #793, 04:06 to 04:32.
46. Forbes Austria, 10 December 2018.
47. Deglmann, Munich Startup, 13 February 2017, quote of Daniel Krauss. Krauss's 2017 podcast and the company-supplied text give other versions, see Exhibit 3.
48. WirtschaftsWoche, 17 October 2016. A newspaper of 2024 wrote that Schwämmlein found the plan through his work in a city council as a pupil, without a source, and the case does not use that claim because a university interview has him studying until 2007.
49. Wüpper, Stuttgarter Zeitung, 2 July 2017, answer to the question on what attracted him to the business, and Engert, OMR Podcast #793, 04:55 to 05:11.
50. Interview with Daniel Krauss, OMR Podcast #445, 16 December 2021, 10:25 to 10:35, audio https://audio.podigee-cdn.net/615356-m-9baa181ab3832ca53bab13edbaabc491.mp3, accessed 2026-10-19.
51. Engert, OMR Podcast #793, 23:25 to 23:49. The transcript does not mark speakers. The words "for us" show that a founder speaks, and the case attributes the sentence to Engert, the guest.
52. Engert, OMR Podcast #793, 06:19 to 07:09. Wüpper, Stuttgarter Zeitung, 2 July 2017, and Deglmann, Munich Startup, 13 February 2017, name the same models.
53. Engert, OMR Podcast #793, 07:13 to 07:23.
54. Schwämmlein, LinkedIn Redaktion podcast, 05:17 to 05:22, and Krauss, OMR Podcast #80, 01:49 to 01:51, both measure the length against events after 30 June 2011, which this case does not describe. The case writer's dating of the implied starts is an inference.
55. Deglmann, Munich Startup, 13 February 2017, first paragraph under the heading "Geld allein ist nicht alles", which dates the first thoughts to 2010 and the civil-law partnership to 2011.
56. Bieber, forschung leben, issue 7-2016, section "Why leave a secure job?". The magazine gives Engert's words in the first person plural.
57. Engert, OMR Podcast #793, 06:03 to 06:16.
58. Engert, OMR Podcast #793, 05:45 to 05:58, and Wüpper, Stuttgarter Zeitung, 2 July 2017.
59. Engert, OMR Podcast #793, 06:03 to 06:16, and OMR, show notes of the episode, 16 April 2025.
60. Sources for Exhibit 1 are in the notes to the text on the Act, the answer of 6 July 2010, the consumer federation and Deutsche Bahn. The 1934 rule comes from the Bundestag paper and the Federal Government's page.
61. Sources for Exhibit 2 are in the notes to the text. The figure on Hamburg to Berlin is Engert's recollection, OMR Podcast #793, 22:44 to 22:52.
62. Sources for Exhibit 3 are those named in the notes to the text. In addition, Wüpper, Stuttgarter Zeitung, 2 July 2017, for Engert 2017, Luthardt, StartingUp, 03/16, for Schwämmlein 2016, and an interview with Schwämmlein, Luzerner Zeitung, 19 February 2018, https://www.luzernerzeitung.ch/schweiz/fernbusse-wie-andre-schwaemmlein-und-zwei-kollegen-vor-5-jahren-darauf-kamen-flixbus-zu-gruenden-ld.81916, accessed 2026-10-19. The company-supplied text is the same answer printed in the FAU alumni interview of July 2019 under Schwämmlein's name and in an interview with Krauss in Wirtschaftsforum, about February 2018, https://www.wirtschaftsforum.de/interviews/flixmobility-gmbh/eine-gute-start-up-idee-sollte-man-in-maximal-zwei-saetzen-erklaeren-koennen, accessed 2026-10-19.
63. Sources for Exhibit 4 are those named in the notes to the section "Three friends and a wish".